

The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

Burnham answers in the House, Starmer vacates it

The House came back on Tuesday 1 September to a Prime Minister it had never questioned and a former Prime Minister it was about to lose. Andy Burnham had been in office for 43 days — “during which,” Kemi Badenoch told him, “I have learned how he puts the milk in his tea and exactly what he thinks about pork scratchings, but I have not had the pleasure of asking him any questions.” His statement on the direction of government ran from 3.39 pm to 6.49 pm, 118 replies by the Official Report, “125 questions” by hers, and “the longest statement in modern history” by his own claim at Prime Minister’s Questions the next day. It opened with a tribute to Sir Keir Starmer, “as he stands down from this place”; that evening the Treasury recorded that “The Chancellor of the Exchequer has this day appointed Sir Keir Starmer to be Steward and Bailiff of the Three Hundreds of Chiltern,” and the Commons register fell to 649. Around it: three more ministerial statements, the Government’s first Prime Minister’s Questions, four divisions on the Representation of the People Bill, all won, the last its Third Reading by 411 to 102, and 6,683 written questions, 6,153 of them dated a single Friday of the recess.

THE MONEY, AND WHAT IT IS FOR

£298 billion

DEFENCE

The DIP is investing £298 billion over the next four years and is assessed to support an additional 60,000 direct and indirect...

£26 billion

DEFENCE

Through £26 billion of investment over the next decade, including major upgrades at Faslane, Portsmouth and Devonport, the...

£20 billion

DEFENCE

The £20 billion of planned investment in new weapons and munitions between 2030 and 2035 reflects the Department’s current...

£14bn

WALES OFFICE

Friend the Prime Minister reaffirmed this Government’s commitment to the £14bn plan for Welsh rail.

THE WEEK IN BRIEF

The Prime Minister’s statement on the direction of government, Tuesday 1 September. Andy Burnham said that from the 1980s the country took a series of wrong turns, with political power centralised and economic power privatised. Sir Iain Duncan Smith asked who wrote it. He offered Cornwall a devolution deal with or without an elected mayor, said summer small boat arrivals had halved on last year, and told the Opposition that in six days his Government would have outlived the Truss Government.

Criminal justice reform, Tuesday 1 September. The Lord Chancellor, Alex Norris, said early release under the Sentencing Act will now exclude all unlawful killing offences, including death by dangerous or drink driving and manslaughter, as well as indecent assault. More than £110 million is being brought forward for prison places. Legislation will end imprisonment for public protection sentences by the end of this Parliament. A written answer on Wednesday moved the first releases from 2 September to 1 October.

Policing in Cleveland, Tuesday 1 September. Shabana Mahmood told the House that at 3.39 in the morning of 22 August a car travelling the wrong way down the A66 hit a marked Cleveland police vehicle. PC Matthew Blades and PC Tom Clough died, as did the five young men in the car. They were thirty-seven and thirty-eight. There have been twenty-seven arrests in a wider investigation into serious and organised crime. The force will receive an extra £2 million.

Foreign Office questions and the Chagos treaty, Tuesday 1 September. Luke Evans asked whether the department has budgeted for future spending on the treaty with Mauritius over the Chagos archipelago, and asked the minister to confirm that the deal is dead. Uma Kumaran said the funding will come from the existing spending review settlements for the Foreign Office and the Ministry of Defence, and gave no figure. Wendy Morton quoted the Government’s own words from April, that the treaty had become impossible to agree at political level after the United States withdrew support.

Prime Minister’s Questions, then the First Secretary, Wednesday 2 September. Kemi Badenoch asked what the Prime Minister had cut to pay for his summer promises. He said tax was the simple answer and that digital identity cards are not a priority. He would not rule out tax rises and would not write the Budget at the Dispatch Box. Asked to state the fiscal rules he gave one sentence, no borrowing for day to day spending and debt falling as a share of the economy by the end of

the Parliament. Louise Haigh then described the new Office of the Prime Minister and Cabinet.

Wales questions and the affordability of housing, Wednesday 2 September. Andrew George asked what discussions the Government has had with the Welsh Government about the affordability of housing. Anna McMorrin said housing is devolved in Wales, and that the Prime Minister announced last week where more than 70,000 social and affordable homes will be built across England over the next ten years. The promise to offer everyone in England a route off the streets by Christmas comes with £442 million. Mr George said the Welsh Government had missed its own social housing target for 2021 to 2026.

Representation of the People Bill, Wednesday 2 September. The week’s four votes were all on this Bill and the Government won all four. Conservative clauses on overseas electors and on campaign material in foreign languages both fell, as did a Liberal Democrat clause for a Royal Commission on a cap on political donations. The Government’s own clauses propose a ban on donations in cryptoassets. Florence Eshalomi answered as the new minister and Katie Lam spoke as the new shadow. The Bill then passed its Third Reading by 411 votes to 102, with the Conservatives and Reform UK voting against, and goes to the House of Lords.

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK’S QUESTIONS

Prisoners’ Release · Dr Kieran Mullan, Conservative

To ask the Secretary of State for Justice, how many offenders will be released (a) on 2 September 2026 and (b) at each of the following monthly release points under the Sentencing Act 2026 by offence including rape, child grooming, sexual assault, manslaughter, causing death by dangerous driving and child cruelty.

THE ANSWER This Government inherited a prisons system days from collapse. We had no choice but to take decisive action to stop our prisons overflowing and keep the public safe.

THE SEAT THAT IS EMPTY

Holborn and St Pancras, vacant since 1 September 2026, when Sir Keir Starmer left the House by the Chiltern Hundreds. No writ has been moved.

If the writ goes this ... **Thu 8 Oct**
A fortnight on **Thu 22 Oct**
At the three-month ... **Thu 7 Jan**

Nothing in statute obliges the House to move the writ, and by convention a Member of the party that held the seat chooses the day. Once it is received the poll follows 21 to 27 working days later, a window wide enough to hold a Thursday whenever the writ is moved.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

Representation of the People Bill: Report Stage: New Clause 65

166 346
Not carried by 180 on 2 September

Representation of the People Bill: Report stage: New Clause 67

105 410
Not carried by 305 on 2 September

Representation of the People Bill: Third Reading

411 102
Carried by 309 on 2 September

Representation of the People Bill: Report Stage: New Clause 88

85 427
Not carried by 342 on 2 September

WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT

Defence	914
Housing	833
Health	704
Cabinet Office	530
Treasury	460
Environment	424
Home Office	400
Business	375
18 others	2,043

THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

67 Defence: Procurement · 39 Defence: Finance · 39 Planning Permission · 28 Defence · 28 Political Parties: Finance · 27 Emergencies: Mobile Phones · 27 Housing: Construction · 26 Animal Experiments · 23 Energy Drinks: Children · 23 Prisoners’ Release

THE FEATURE

Seven hundred and three questions from Huntingdon

Ben Obese-Jecty is the Conservative Member of Parliament for Huntingdon and holds no front bench post. On Friday 28 August he tabled 684 written questions and on Tuesday 1 September he added nineteen. That is 703 in all and 449 of them are to the Ministry of Defence. Forty-four cite the 2025 Strategic Defence Review by recommendation number. Twenty-two cite the department’s annual report and accounts. Seventeen go through the equipment statistics published on 20 August and ask what happened to each vehicle the fleet is smaller by. Others go row by row through the government’s major projects tables. There is a second front at the Ministry of Justice, with eleven questions on prison accommodation. By Wednesday night one of the 703 had been answered.